FinAfrica

Financial Inclusion · East Africa

Access to finance is access to opportunity.

FinAfrica presentation

1. Overview
2. problem Definition
3. key Findings
4. Action fields
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Who we are

FinAfrica is an NGO working at the intersection of **data, policy, and social justice**. We use machine learning to identify who is most at risk of financial exclusion — and translate those insights into opportunities on the ground.

Our focus: **minimising false negatives** — making sure we never miss the people who need help most.

🇰🇪 Kenya

Highest banking penetration in region · M-Pesa pioneer

🇷🇼 Rwanda

Strong digital infrastructure · low informal sector

🇺🇬 Uganda

Large rural population · rapid mobile growth

🇹🇿 Tanzania

Lowest inclusion in dataset · high gender gap

Millions excluded – not by chance

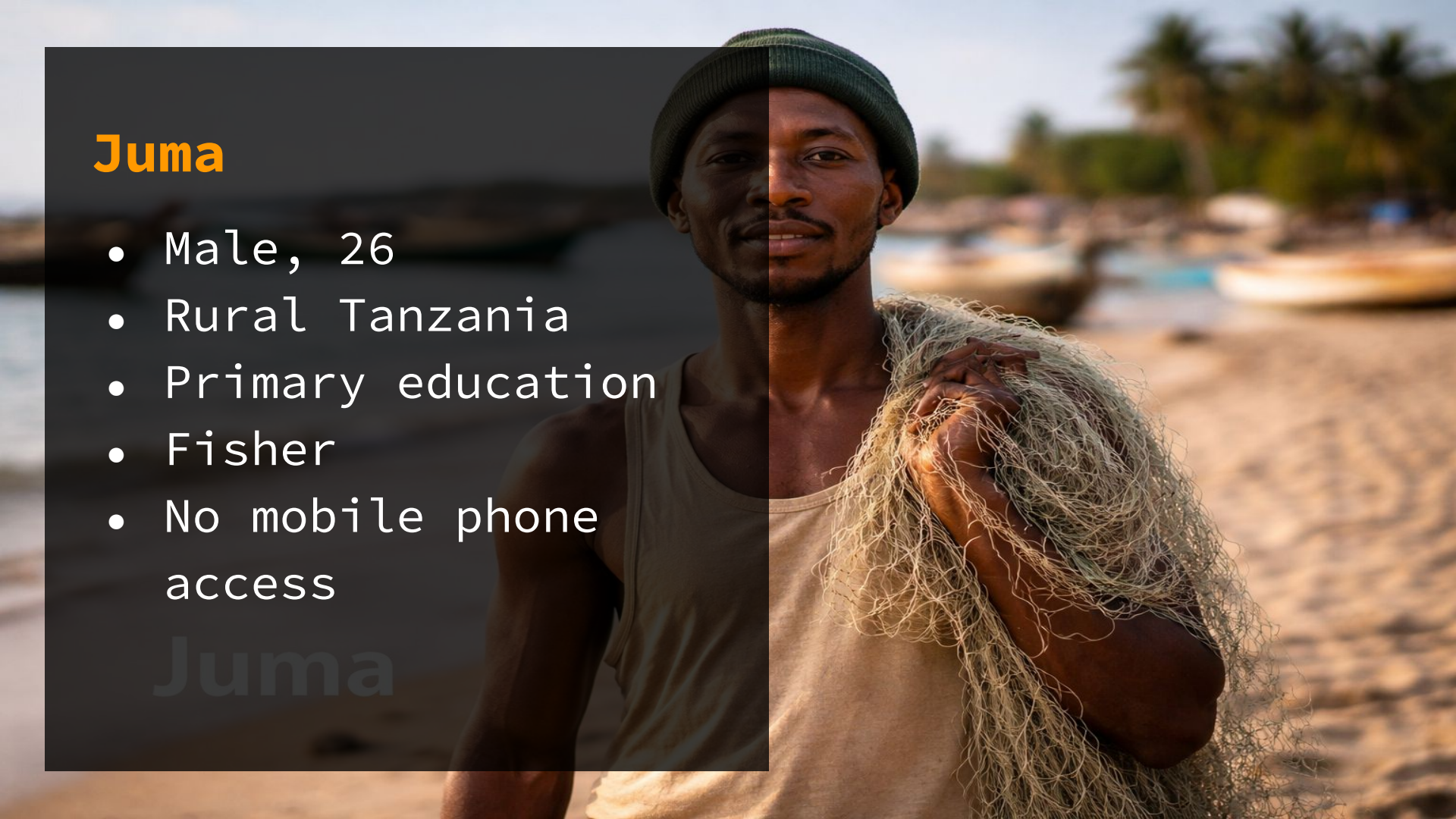
Key Questions:

1. **Which groups are most at risk of financial exclusion across countries?**
2. How does gender inequality affect access to financial services?
3. Which role does mobile phone access play as an inclusion enabler?
4. How do rural vs. urban populations differ in financial access?
5. What role does the formal education play?

Aline

- Female, 28
- Lives in rural Rwanda
- Primary education
- No access to mobile phone
- Limited access to formal financial services

"I work hard every harvest season. But without a bank account, I keep my savings in the house – and pray nothing happens."



Juma

- Male, 26
- Rural Tanzania
- Primary education
- Fisher
- No mobile phone access

Juma

Grace

- Female, 38
- Urban Kenya
- Higher education
- Government employee
- Has mobile phone access

"My salary goes straight into my account. I use mobile banking with M-Pesa daily."

KNOW YOUR CHANCES TO OPEN A BANK ACCOUNT

Answer **7** simple questions. Get your personal score and a clear path to financial participation - in minutes!

🌍 Country · 📱 Phone · 💼 Work · 🎓 School → ✨ Your score

WHAT FINAFRICA DOES FOR YOU

🎯 **Personal probability score**
Based on real data from 23,000 people like you.

💡 **Concrete next steps**
Simple actions to improve your score, step by step.

🖼️

Icon-first, no reading needed
Works even with limited literacy or a basic phone.

🔒

Private & safe
No account needed. No data saved. Answers stay with you.

⚡

Works on any device
Café, smartphone, tablet — even on slow connections.

Problem:

Find the unbanked who are ready to bank: predict adoption likelihood to guide targeted financial inclusion at scale.

Numeric features have no signal; categorical features tell the story.

Numeric features

Year

2016 & 2018

Bimodal peaks
Two survey years

Age of Respondent

Mean: 38.81 yrs
Median: 35 yrs

Right-skewed
Peak: 26–35 age group

Household Size

Mean: 3.80
Median: 3

Right-skewed
Most: 2–5 people

Categorical features distribution

Job Type

Self-employed 30% • Farming 25%
Formal Private 20%

Education Level

Primary 35% • No formal 28%
Secondary 25%

Location Type

Rural 65% • Urban 35%

Gender

Female 51% • Male 49%

Cellphone Access

Yes 64% • No 36%

Marital Status

Married 47% • Single 33%

23,525 respondents, zero missing data, 2.1:1 class imbalance.

Dataset composition

Respondents	Features	Data Quality
23,525	13	Clean
4 countries	demographic & socioeconomic	zero missing, no outliers

Target distribution (bank account ownership)

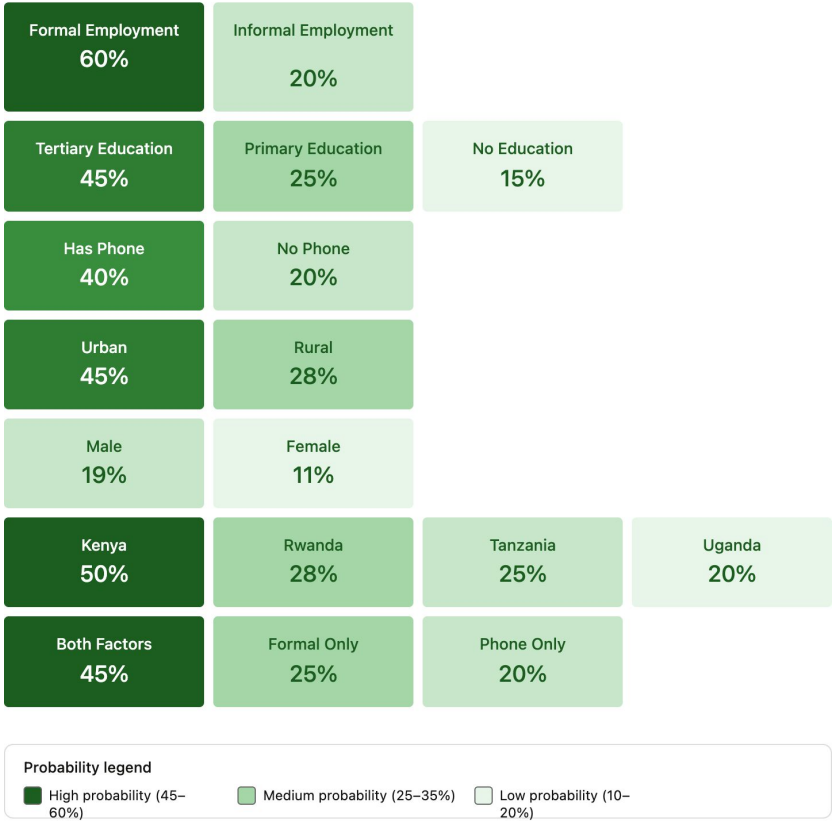
No Account	Has Account	Imbalance Ratio
68%	32%	2.1:1
16,117 respondents	7,408 respondents	class imbalance

Geographic coverage

Kenya	Rwanda	Tanzania	Uganda
✓	✓	✓	✓

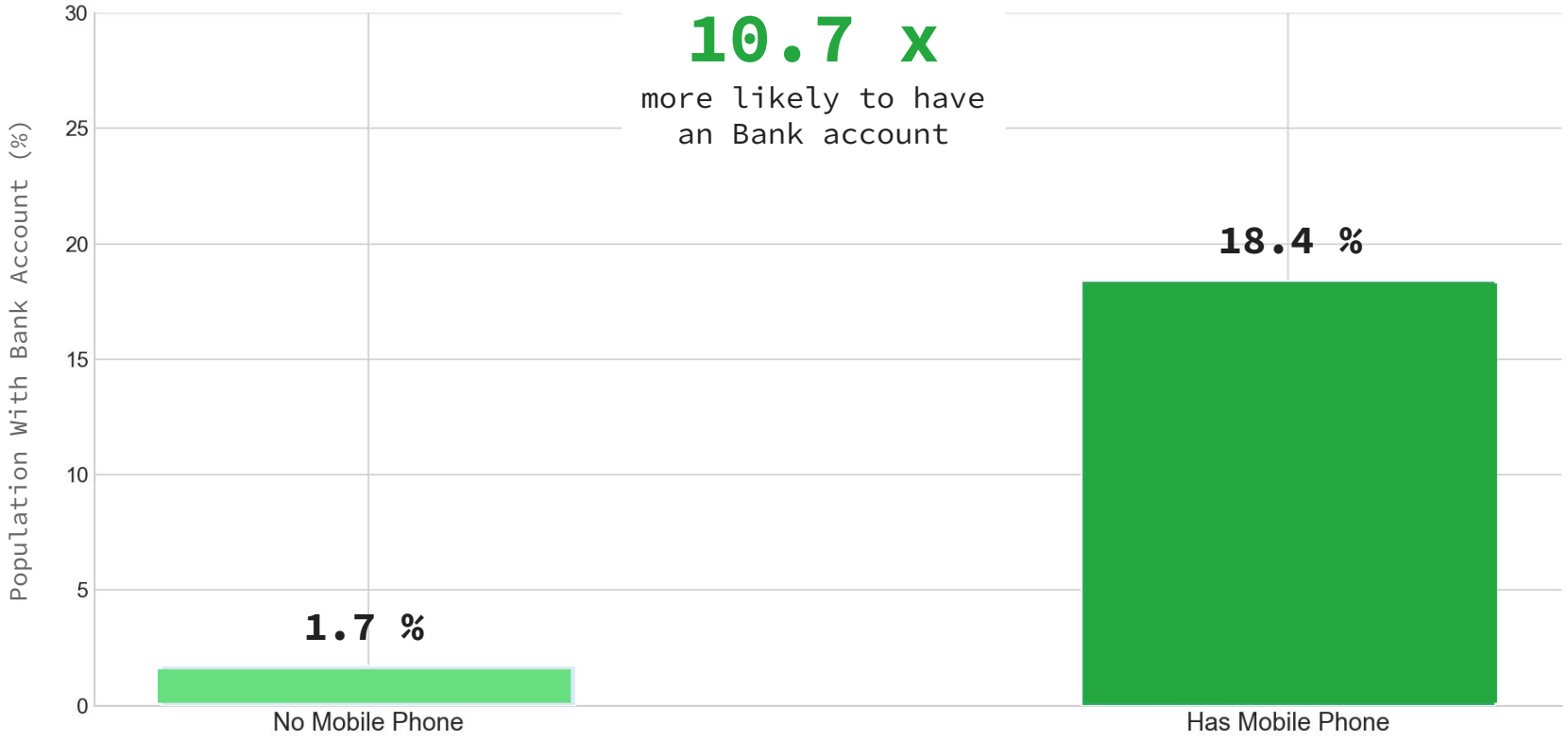
Formal work wins by 3x, education and access multiply the effect.

- **Formal employment dominates (60%)** 🥇
- **Education creates** clear tiers—tertiary 45%, primary 25%, none 15%
- **Digital access** doubles chances **(40% vs. 20%)**
- **Location moderates** impact—urban 45% vs. rural 28%
- **Gender reveals** structural barriers— **males 19% vs. females 11%**
- **Country context** varies significantly— **Kenya 50% vs. Uganda 20%**

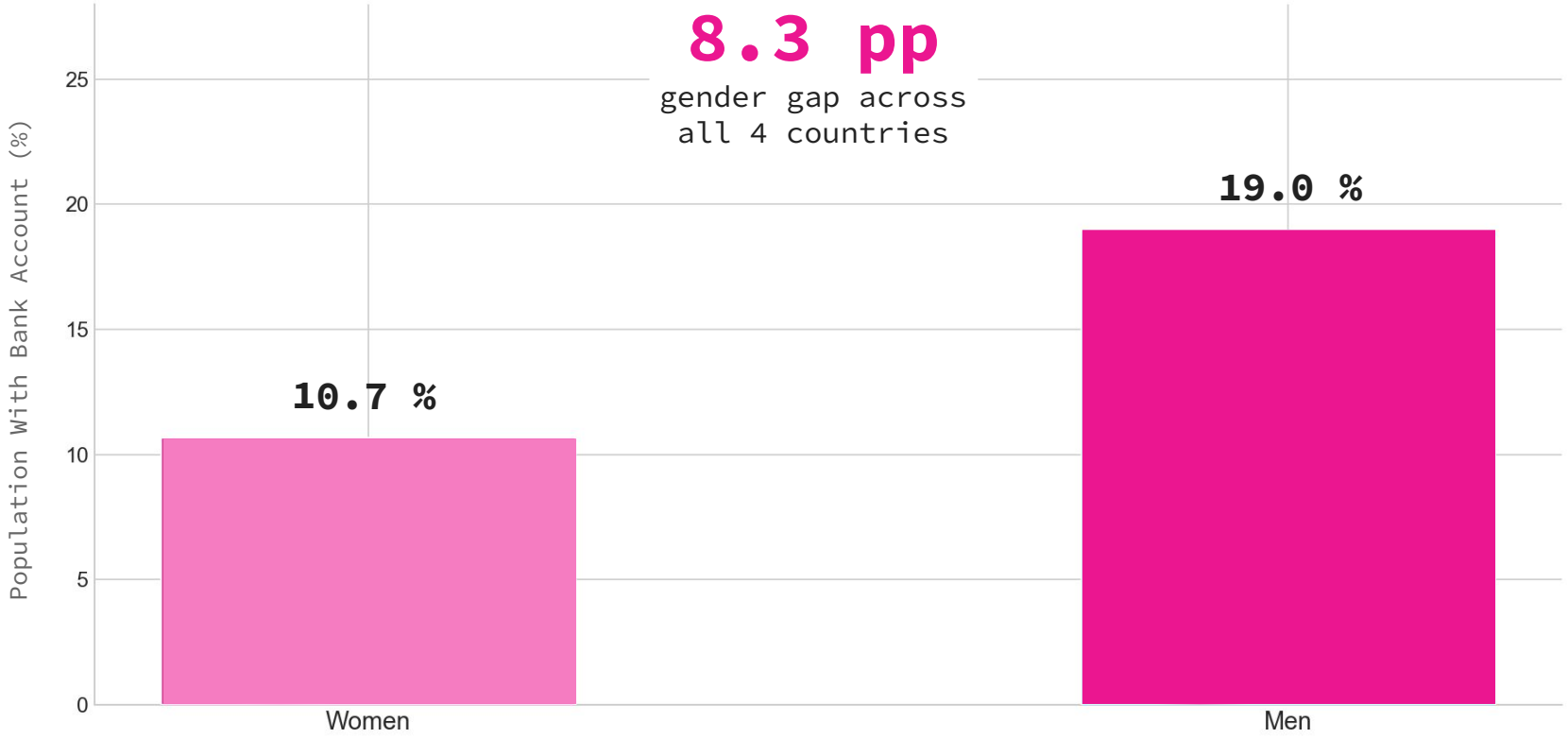


KEY FINDINGS

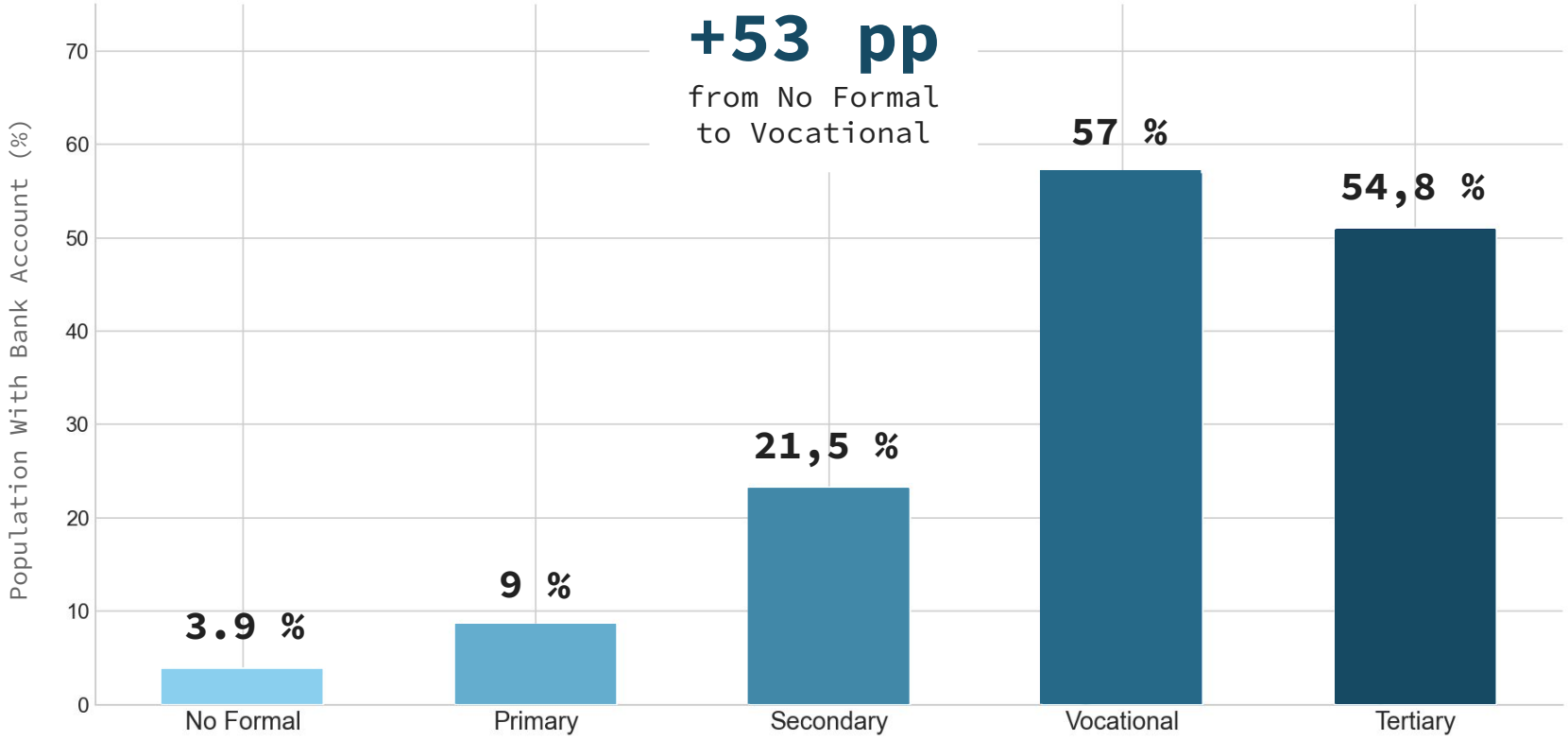
Mobile phone access – the biggest enabler



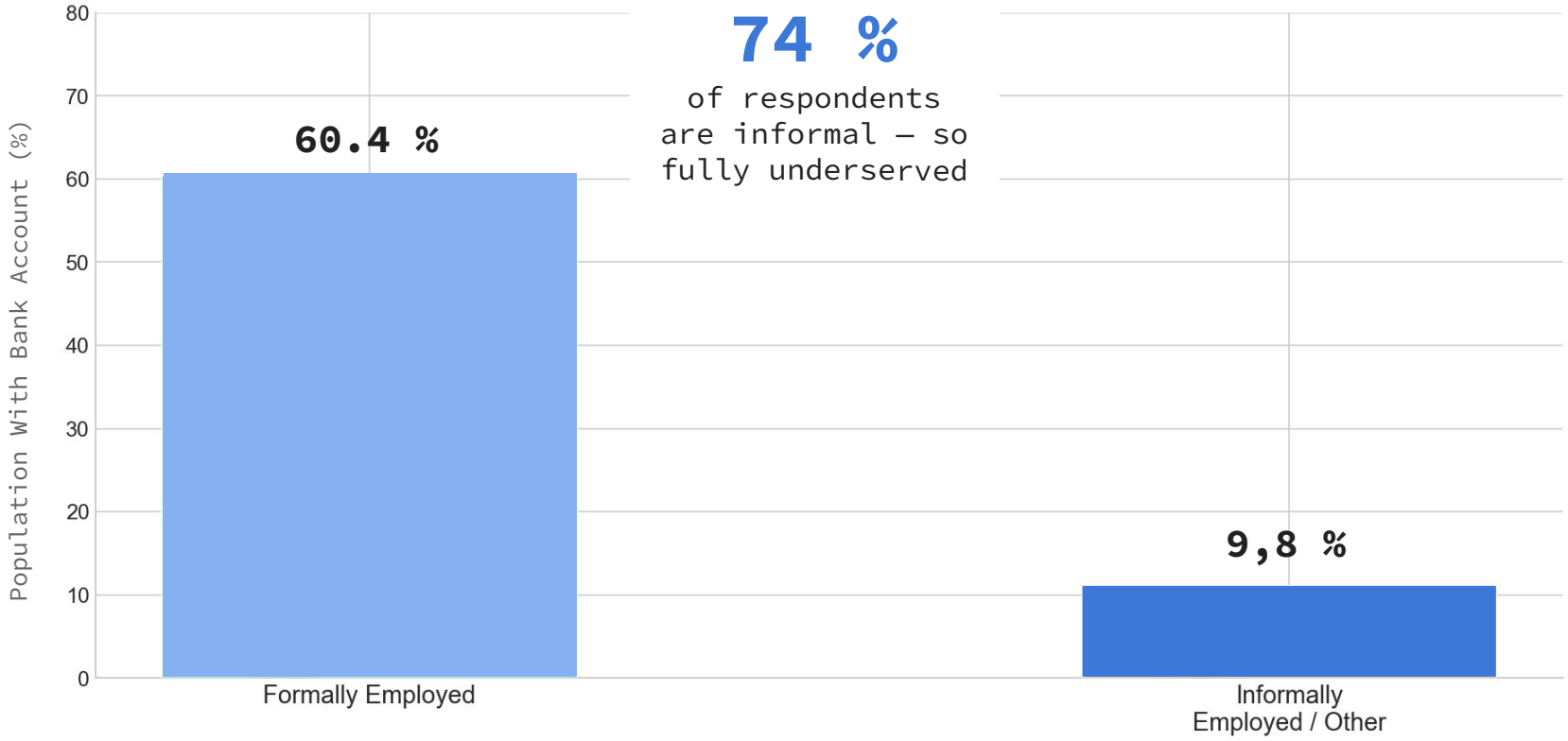
Women are systematically left behind



Education is the strongest predictor of financial access

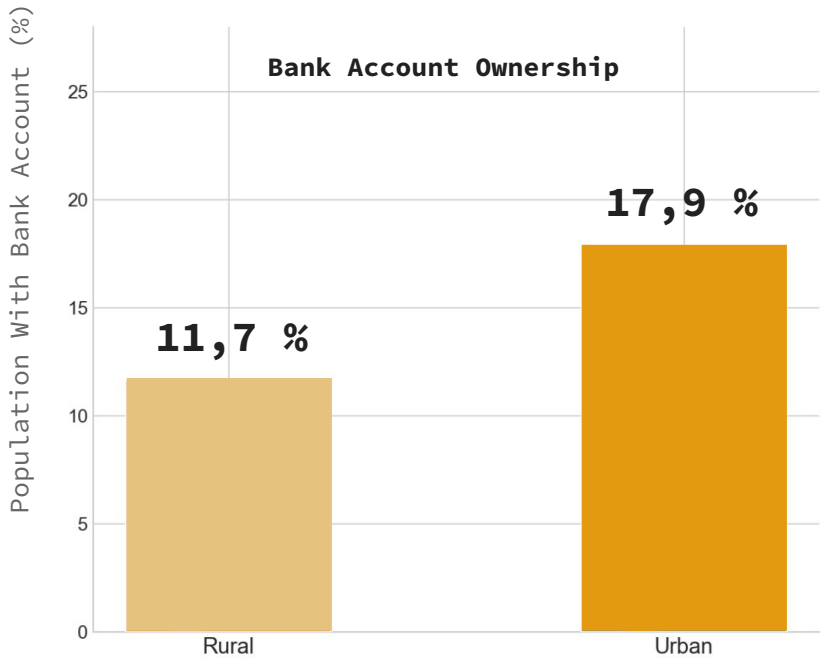


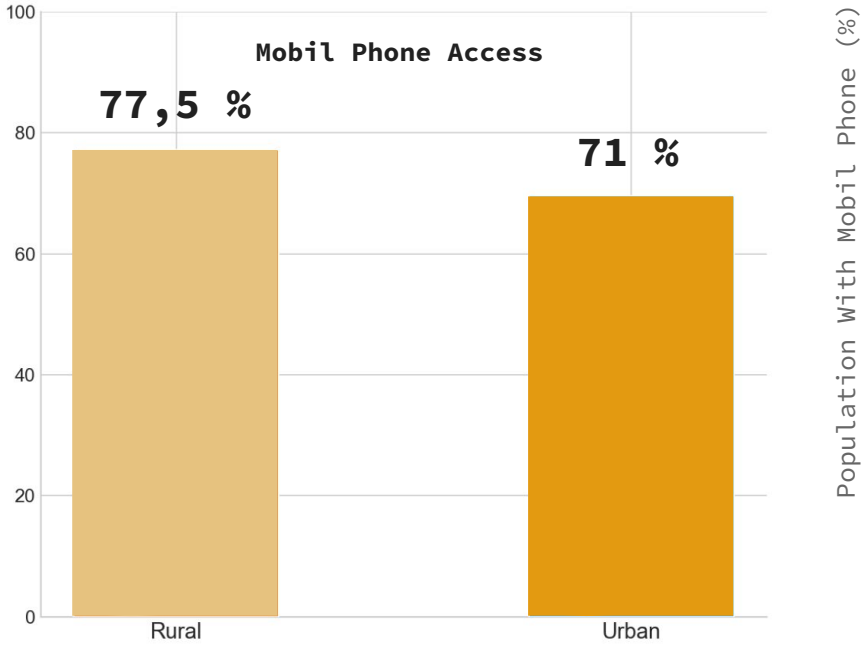
Banking products do not reach informal workers



Rural vs Urban: 6.2 pp gap in banking but access is similar

The barrier is not technology.
It is missing products!





FinAfrica 5 key findings

10.7 x

more bank accounts with a mobile phone

8.3 pp

gender gap (Men vs Women)

+53 pp

education jump (No formal → Vocational)

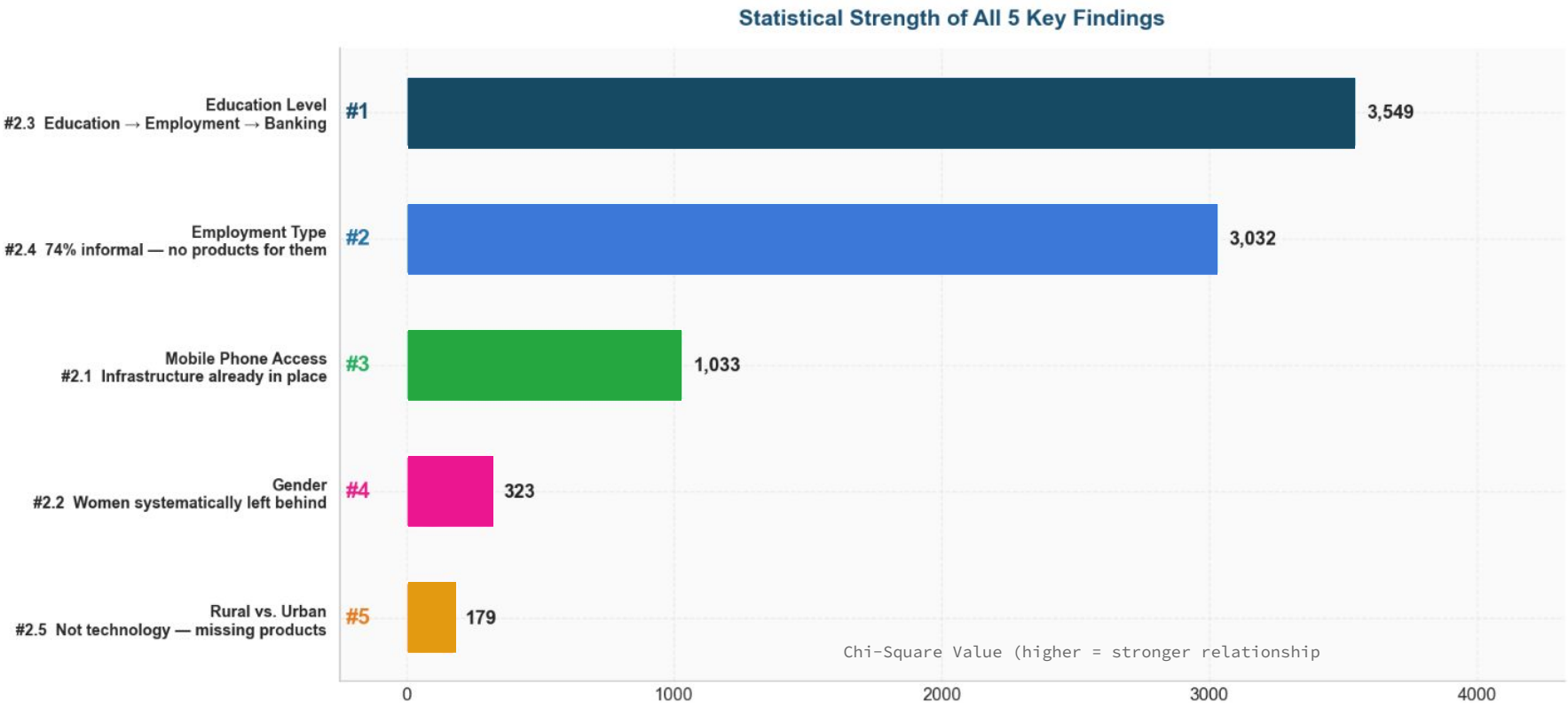
74 %

There are not the right products for informal workers

6.2 pp

rural–urban gap despite similar phone access

FinAfrica 5 key findings



ACTION FIELDS

Our Top-3 fields of action

#1 - Phone first financial onboarding:

- Train community agents to demonstrate mobile money in local languages, door to door
- Align with M-PESA on a common strategy how to improve financial inclusion
- Partner with telecoms to subsidise SIM cards and basic handsets for unbanked households

#2 - Closing the financial gender gap:

- Launch women-specific phone ownership programs with private SIM registration support
- Formalise existing informal savings groups (e.g. VSLA in tanzania) into regulated mobile products
- Engage male household heads and community leaders as allies, not obstacles

#3 - Building financial fluency:

- Integrate practical financial literacy into primary school curricula across all four countries
- Develop teacher training modules — financial education quality depends on teacher confidence
- For adults: deliver short workshops through market days, church meetings, and cooperatives

#1 ACTION FIELD - PHONE-FIRST FINANCIAL ONBOARDING

CONCRETE ACTIONS:

- Partner with telecoms to subsidise SIM cards and basic handsets for unbanked households
- Train community agents to demonstrate mobile money in local languages, door to door
- Advocate for zero-fee, zero-minimum-balance mobile wallet products
- Run phone ownership programs specifically targeting women, who have lower access rates
- Map mobile money agent density in target communities — fill gaps before launching education programs

TAKE AWAY

The path to financial inclusion runs through the phone, not the bank branch. The gap between phone ownership and financial product adoption is the most actionable space..

#2 ACTION FIELD - CLOSING THE FINANCIAL GENDER GAP

CONCRETE ACTIONS:

- Launch women-specific phone ownership programs with private SIM registration support
- Formalise existing informal savings groups (chamas, table banking) into regulated mobile products
- Engage male household heads and community leaders as allies, not obstacles
- Design products for irregular, small-amount income cycles typical of women traders
- Track gender disaggregated outcomes in all program metrics — visibility drives accountability

TAKE AWAY

The gender gap in bank accounts is not about capability. It reflects that financial products were designed for formally employed, urban, male users. Closing the gap means redesigning the products and the access pathways — not educating women differently.

#3 ACTION FIELD - BUILDING FINANCIAL FLUENCY

CONCRETE ACTIONS:

- Integrate practical financial literacy into primary school curricula across all four countries
- Develop teacher training modules — financial education quality depends on teacher confidence
- For adults: deliver short workshops through market days, church meetings, and cooperatives
- Design all education content for low-literacy audiences — visual, oral, and in local languages
- Focus on practical skills: how to register a mobile wallet, how to save in small amounts, what credit history means

TAKE AWAY

Education is the slowest lever but the one with the longest compounding return. A child who learns basic financial concepts before entering the workforce enters adulthood with different assumptions about money, saving, and credit than one who does not..

#4 ACTION FIELD - SERVING THE WORKERS THAT GET IGNORED

CONCRETE ACTIONS:

- Integrate practical financial literacy into primary school curricula across all four countries
- Develop teacher training modules — financial education quality depends on teacher confidence
- For adults: deliver short workshops through market days, church meetings, and cooperatives
- Design all education content for low-literacy audiences — visual, oral, and in local languages
- Focus on practical skills: how to register a mobile wallet, how to save in small amounts, what credit history means

TAKE AWAY

Most financial products were designed for salaried employees with predictable monthly income. The majority of working-age adults in these four countries do not fit that profile. The gap is a product design failure, not a population failure.

#5 ACTION FIELD - INTEGRATED RURAL OUTREACH

CONCRETE ACTIONS:

- Map rural mobile agent networks before deploying education programs — infrastructure first
- Train and pay local community members as mobile money agents — keeps value in the community
- Deliver all content through trusted local institutions: schools, health clinics, religious centres
- Design savings products around agricultural income cycles — harvest-time deposits, off-season microloans
- Advocate for country-specific rural financial inclusion policies — Tanzania and Uganda showed the largest gaps

TAKE AWAY

Rural financial exclusion is not one problem — it is two reinforcing problems. Programs that bring financial education to communities with no mobile agent network, or that deploy mobile money infrastructure without local literacy support, will consistently underperform.

FINAFRICA OUTLOOK

Our next steps

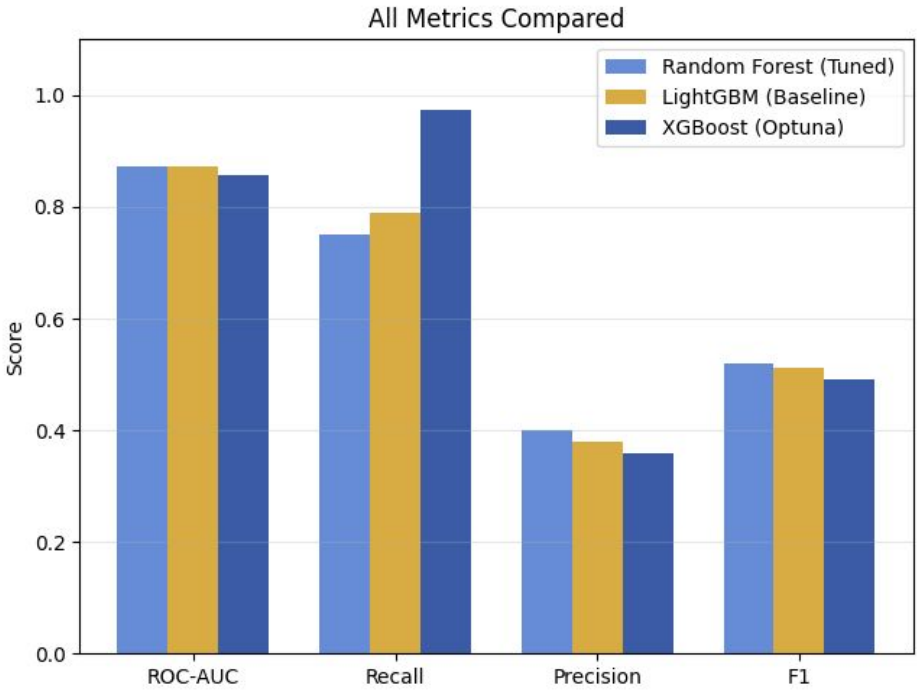
OVERVIEW:

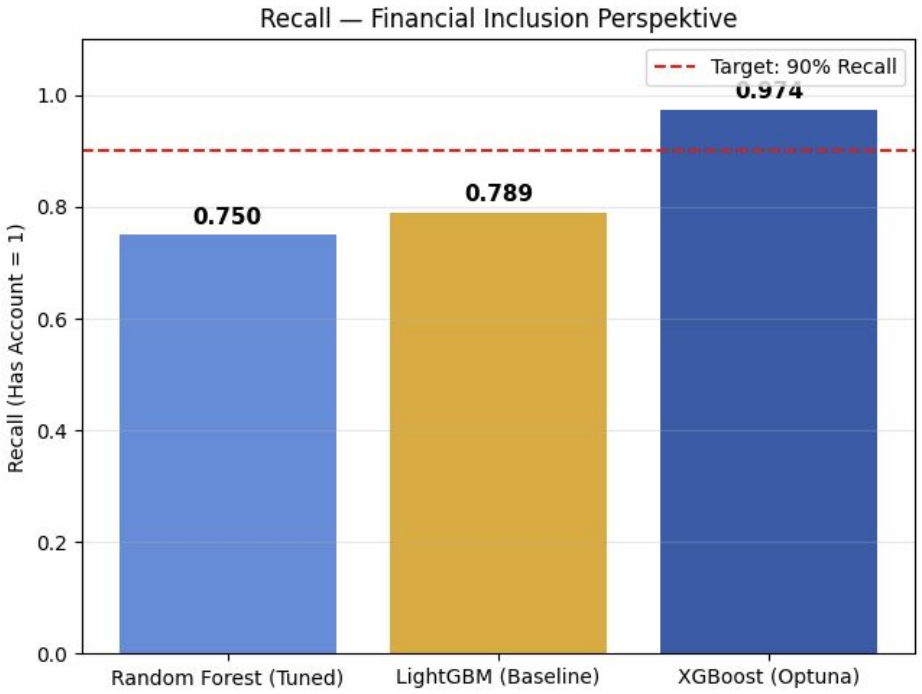
- Further improve the model by making it more country specific
- Deploy our financial inclusion tool and promote it to raise awareness
- Validate and reassess our model on real-life training data
- Make the code open-source to get feedback from the community and provide our tool to other countries
- Tackle add. critical barriers like strict documentation requirements, regulatory process, ID issues etc.

Every person in Africa should be able to access affordable financial services—such as savings, credit, payments, and insurance—regardless of location, gender, or formal identification, empowering economic participation.

Backup

Model Comparison





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Thank you for your attention!